

Refresh, Consolidate, Prune

Deleting pages to improve rankings feels wrong and is frequently correct.

Bottom line

Publishing is the start of a page's life. AI-cited content runs about 25.7% fresher than uncited content, and thin pages in one part of a site can suppress good content elsewhere on the same domain. Every page you own is on one of four tracks: keep, update, merge, or remove.

The four tracks

Every URL on your site is one of these. Decide deliberately rather than by neglect.

Keep. Performing well, still accurate, still matches intent. Leave it and re-check on schedule.

Update. The topic still matters, the page has decayed. Most of your content lives here.

Merge. Two or more pages serving the same intent. Consolidate into the strongest and 301 the rest. This is the cannibalization fix from Section 8.

Remove. No traffic, no links, no strategic purpose, and no realistic path to any. Redirect to the nearest relevant page, or return 410 if there is nowhere sensible to send people.

Why pruning works

From Section 3: evidence points to **domain-level quality weighting**, where thin or low-value content in one section can suppress genuinely good content elsewhere on the same domain. [practitioner]

That is why the standard post-core-update playbook is subtractive first: consolidate, remove, then add. A site with 400 pages where 300 are thin is usually outperformed by the same site with 100 good ones.

The emotional obstacle is real. Those pages took work. Sunk cost is not a ranking factor.

The refresh cycle

13 weeks on priority pages is the working recommendation, with AI-cited content measured at roughly **25.7% fresher** than uncited content. [practitioner]

That does not mean rewriting everything quarterly. It means reviewing priority pages quarterly and updating what has decayed.

What counts as a real update:

- New data replacing outdated numbers
- New sections covering questions that emerged since publication
- Removing advice that is no longer true
- Re-checking the SERP, because intent may have moved (Section 4)
- Adding evidence, from the Section 14 modifiers

What does not count: changing the date, swapping a few words, adding a paragraph of filler. Google is measuring whether the content changed meaningfully, not whether the timestamp did. Fake freshness is a recognized pattern and it does not work.

Finding what needs work

Decay detection in Search Console. Performance, compare last 3 months to the previous 3 months, sort by click difference ascending. The biggest losers are your update queue.

The position 5 to 15 report. From Section 10, the highest-return view in Search Console. These pages already rank and already earn impressions. Moving position 8 to 4 is roughly 400% more clicks.

Zero-traffic audit. Pages with no clicks and no impressions in 6 months. Cross-check against internal links and backlinks before removing anything: a page with no traffic but real backlinks should be merged, not deleted, so the links survive.

Intent drift. Re-search your top 10 queries. If the SERP now returns a different content type than when you wrote the page, the page is mismatched and needs restructuring, not refreshing.

How to consolidate properly

- 1 Pick the winner.** Usually the page with the most backlinks, traffic, or the best URL.
- 2 Merge the content.** Take what is genuinely valuable from the losers into the winner. Do not just concatenate, integrate.
- 3 301 every loser to the winner.** Not to the homepage. A redirect to an irrelevant page is treated as a soft 404.
- 4 Update internal links** to point directly at the winner rather than through a redirect.
- 5 Keep the redirects in place.** Indefinitely. Removing them later breaks external links.

How to remove properly

- **301 to the closest relevant page** if one exists.
- **410 Gone** if nothing is relevant. It signals permanent removal and drops the URL from the index faster than a 404. [practitioner]

- **Never mass-delete without checking backlinks.** A page with external links has value even with no traffic. Redirect it.
- **Do the removal in batches** and watch what happens, rather than deleting 200 pages in one afternoon.

The audit that drives it

Build one row per URL:

Column	Source
URL	crawl
Clicks, last 6 months	Search Console
Impressions, last 6 months	Search Console
Internal links pointing at it	crawl
External backlinks	Ahrefs, Semrush, or Search Console Links
Cluster it belongs to	your Section 8 map
Last meaningful update	your records
Track	keep / update / merge / remove

The Track column is the deliverable. Everything else exists to decide it.

Why this matters

most sites accumulate content and never subtract. That is how a site ends up with 300 pages, 40 of which produce everything and 260 of which are quietly suppressing them. The subtraction is the work almost nobody does, and it is often the single highest-return action available on an established site.

Do this now

- 1 **Build the audit sheet** with the columns above. Even a rough version on 50 URLs is useful.
- 2 **Run decay detection:** Search Console, last 3 months versus previous 3 months, sorted by click loss.
- 3 **Run the zero-traffic query:** no clicks and no impressions in 6 months.
- 4 **Cross-check zero-traffic pages against backlinks** before marking anything remove.
- 5 **Assign a track to every URL.** Keep, update, merge, or remove. No blanks.

- 6 Execute one merge properly:** pick the winner, integrate the content, 301 the loser, update internal links.
- 7 Remove or redirect five genuinely dead pages.**
- 8 Update your single highest-value decayed page,** with real changes not a date bump.
- 9 Put a quarterly reminder in your calendar** to re-run this.

Capstone step

Every URL on your capstone site now has an assigned track, one merge is complete, dead pages are removed or redirected, and your highest-value decayed page is genuinely updated. The site is now smaller and stronger, which is the point.

Key takeaways

- Every URL is on one of four tracks: keep, update, merge, remove. Decide deliberately, because neglect defaults everything to keep.
- Thin content in one part of a site can suppress good content elsewhere on the domain. That is why the post-core-update playbook is subtractive first.
- A real update replaces data, adds sections, and removes what is no longer true. Changing the date is not an update and does not work.
- Never delete a page with backlinks. Redirect it, so the links survive.